The Path to Elite Engineering Performance

Leveraging DORA 2024 Insights & The Cultural Frameworks for Transformation.

Diagnostic & Roadmap for Engineering Leaders | 2025 Edition

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AI is ubiquitous, but not a silver bullet.

We are adopting tools faster than we are adapting our ways of working.

81%

of organizations prioritized AI adoption.

75%

of engineers rely on AI daily.

39%

have little to no trust in AI output.

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Defining the Standard: The Metrics of Elite Performance

Metric	Elite Performer (Green)	Low Performer (Red)
Deployment Frequency	On-demand (Multiple/day)	Monthly or less
Lead Time for Changes	< 1 hour	1-6 months
Time to Restore Service	< 1 hour	1 week +
Change Failure Rate	0-15%	46-60%

New 2024 Insight: Rework Rate is the new proxy for software stability.

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Process and tools fail when culture is broken.

	PATHOLOGICAL (Power-Oriented)	**BUREAUCRATIC** (Rule-Oriented)	**GENERATIVE** (Performance-Oriented)
Information:	Hoarded	Ignored	Actively Sought
Messengers:	Shot	Tolerated	Trained
Responsibilities:	Shirked	Compartmentalized	Shared
Bridging:	Discouraged	Allowed but Discouraged	Rewarded
Failure:	Covered Up	Justice	Leads to Inquiry
New Ideas:	Crushed	Create Problems	Welcomed

The Check Engine Light: If DORA metrics are low, check your Westrum score first.

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The Anatomy of a Toxic Engineering Culture

Activity Theater

Optimizing for busy-work. Celebrating closed tickets over business impact.

Trust Deficit

Multiple approvals required. Mistakes are punished. “Cover Your A**” behavior.

Context Vacuum

Engineers don't know strategy. Roadmap appears arbitrary. Zero customer feedback loop.

Synchronous Addiction

30+ hours of meetings/week. "Let's jump on a call" is default. Instant response expected.

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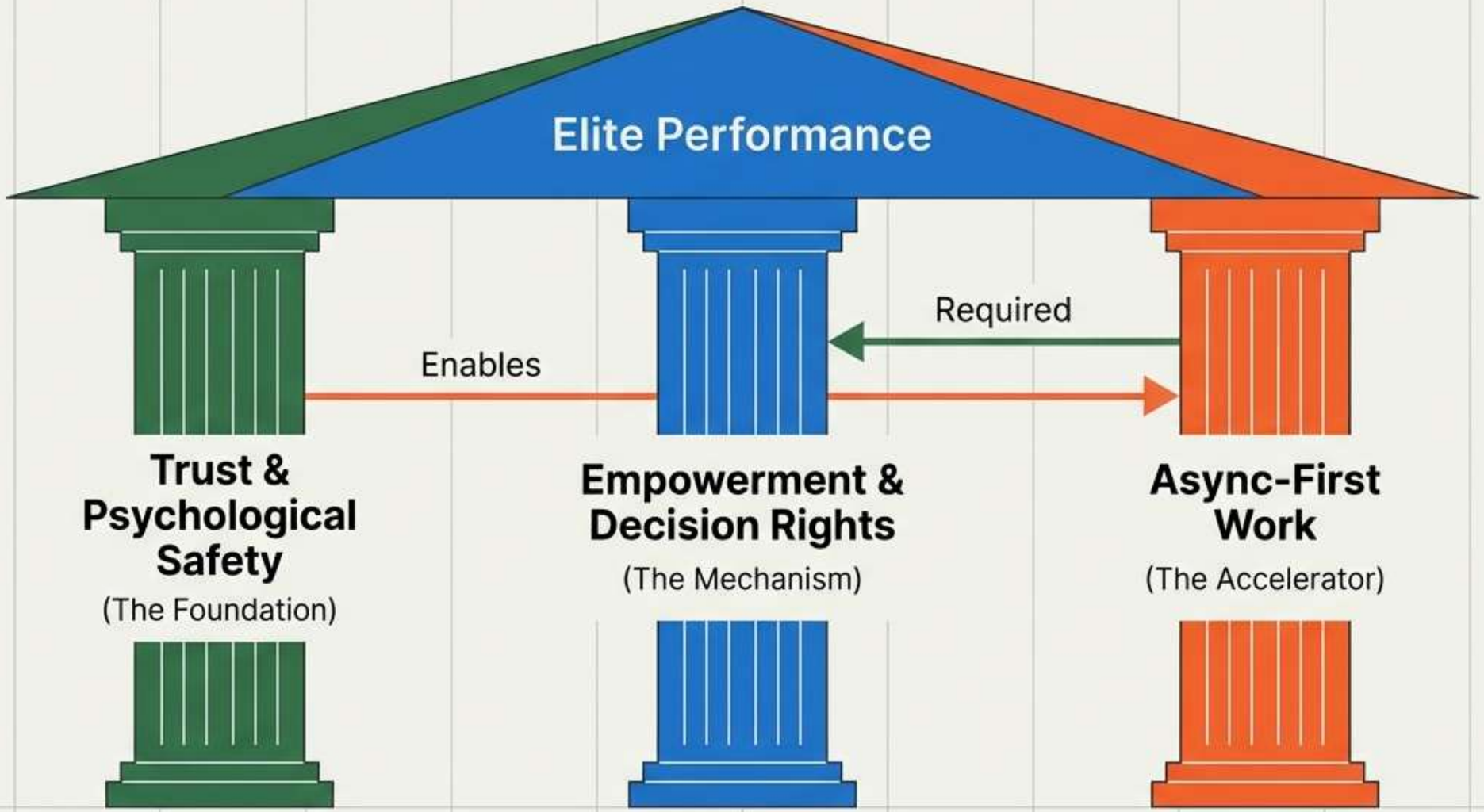
The Framework for Elite Culture



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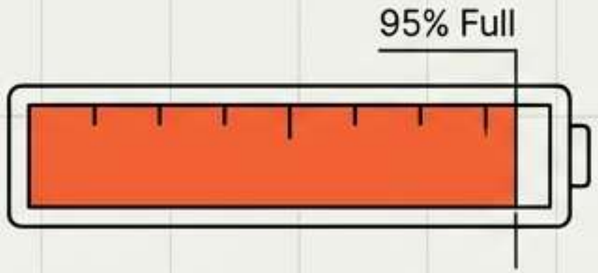
Capability 1: Operationalizing Trust

Psychological safety is not about being nice. It is about being safe to speak up.

Blameless Postmortems

Investigate systems, not people. “Why did the API allow this?” not “Who broke it?”

The Error Budget



Define acceptable failure (e.g., 5% of deployments). If within budget, failure has zero consequences.

Leadership Vulnerability

Leaders admit mistakes first. Failure leads to inquiry, not justice.

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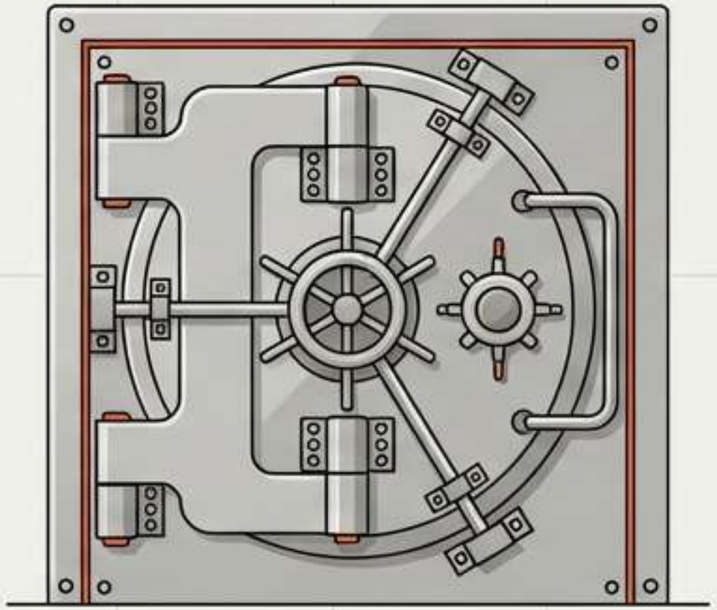
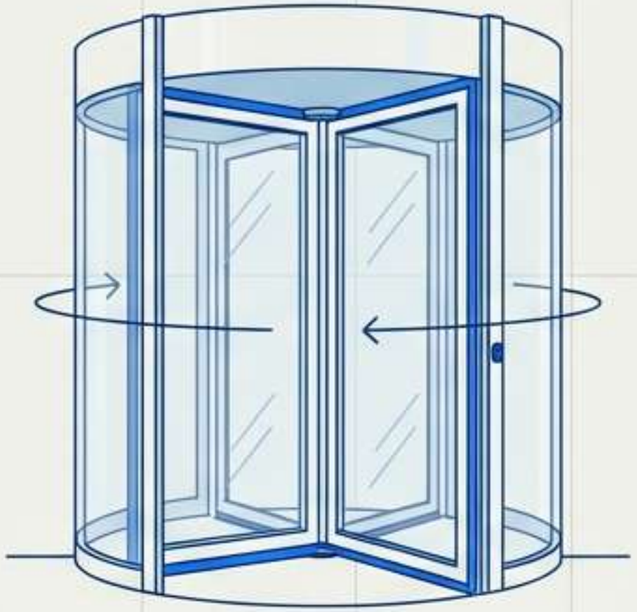
Capability 2: Empowerment via Decision Rights
Move from Permission to Guided Autonomy.

Type 1 Decisions (Irreversible)



High stakes. Hard to reverse.
Requires Leadership Consultation.
Example: Changing Cloud Providers.

Type 2 Decisions (Reversible)



Low stakes. Easily fixed. Delegated to Team.
Example: Choosing a library, prioritizing tech debt.

Prerequisite: You cannot delegate decisions if you hoard context.

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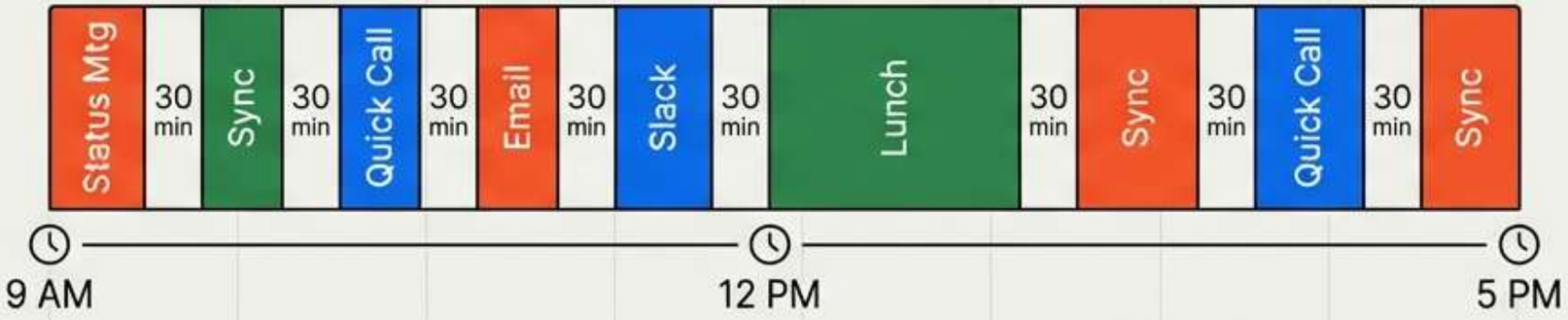
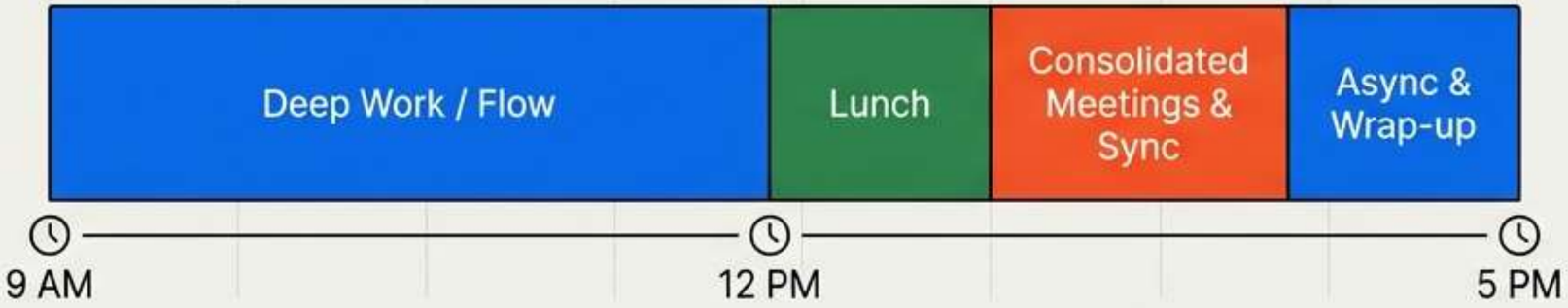
Capability 3: Breaking the Synchronous Addiction

Shift from constant meetings to deep, asynchronous work.

The Fragmented Day (Low Performer)



The Deep Work Day (Elite Performer)



Key Metrics:

- **Meeting Load:** Target < 10 hours/week.
- **Deep Work:** Protected 3+ hour blocks.
- **Communication:** Default to writing, not meetings.

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The 90-Day Playbook: Phase 1 (Weeks 0-4)

Signal Change & **Stop the Bleeding**.

- [x] **Establish Baseline.**
  Measure DORA metrics & Westrum score.
- [x] **Kill One Hated Thing.**
  Remove a useless meeting or process immediately to buy goodwill.
- [x] **Public Reversal.**
  Leadership publicly reverses a decision based on team feedback.
- [x] **Publish Framework.**
  Release the Type 1 / Type 2 decision matrix.

Prerequisite: Leadership alignment is critical for public reversals.

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The 90-Day Playbook: Phases 2 & 3 (Months 2-3)

Foundation & Acceleration.

Context Distribution.

Share business metrics (runway, revenue) with all engineers.

Failure Celebration.

Publicly celebrate an intelligent failure that provided learning.

Documentation Sprint.

Document the top 10 repeated questions to enable async work.

Shadow Audit.

Leadership removes themselves from 50% of decision loops.

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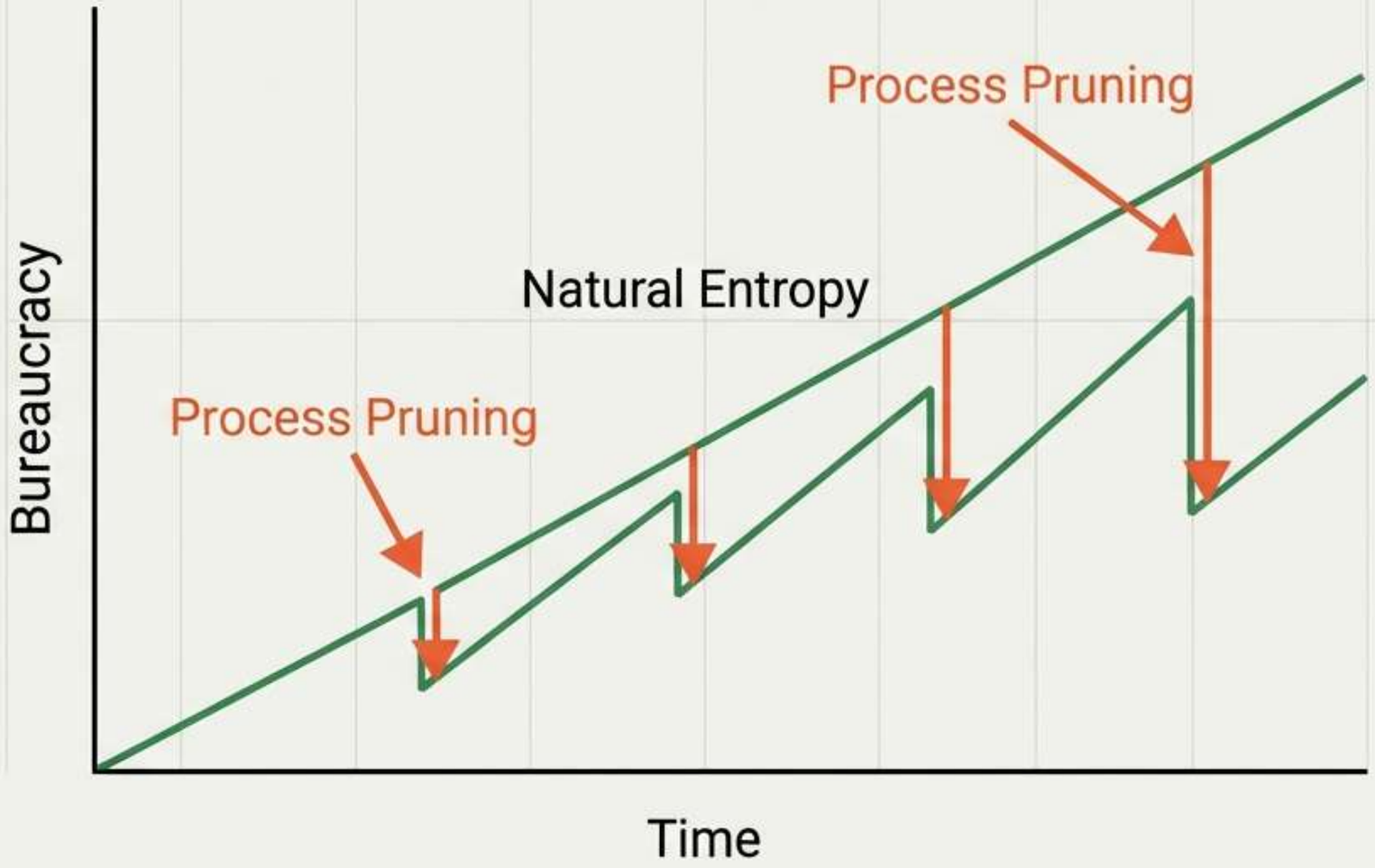
Sustaining Performance: Fighting Entropy



Sustainability Mechanisms:

1. **Hiring Filter:** Screen for writing skills and autonomy.
2. **Promotion:** Do not promote information hoarders.
3. **Quarterly Process Pruning:** Audit and kill unused processes.

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The Joel Test 2025

A Checklist for Foundational Health.

- [ ] Are deployments fully automated?
- [ ] Do engineers have safe access to production observability?
- [ ] Is there a blameless incident response process?
- [ ] Are deep work blocks (3+ hours) protected daily?
- [ ] Is security shifted left (automated in CI)?
- [ ] Is compensation transparent and fair?

12-15 = Elite. < 7 = Crisis Mode.

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The Business Case: Culture is a Strategic Asset

208x

More frequent deployments than low performers.

7x

More likely to exceed reliability targets.

2x

More likely to exceed organizational goals (profitability).

50%

Lower burnout rates. Top performer attrition is only 5-10%.

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Start Your Journey to Elite

Measure: You cannot improve what you don’t track.

Culture: It is the engine that drives the metrics.

Leadership: It starts with your vulnerability.

“The best teams are those that achieve elite improvement, not necessarily elite performance.”
— DORA 2024

Run the DORA ‘Quick Check’ Assessment Today.

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